

The Institutional Stance (Jara-Ettinger & Dunham, 2024)

Prepared by Joseph Low

Research Engineer @ Metagov

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Metagov



Public AI



Outline

1. Introduction
2. Three Stages of the Institutional Stance
3. Institutions as Graphs
4. Creating New Institutions
5. Conclusion

Introduction

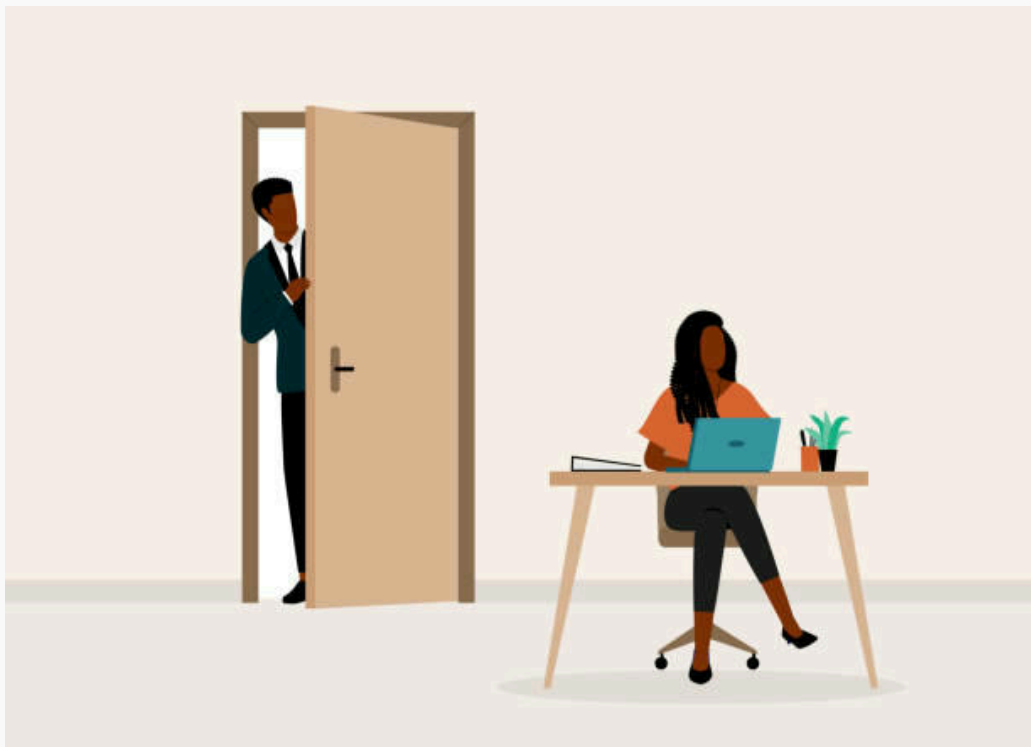


The Puzzle: Friday at the Office



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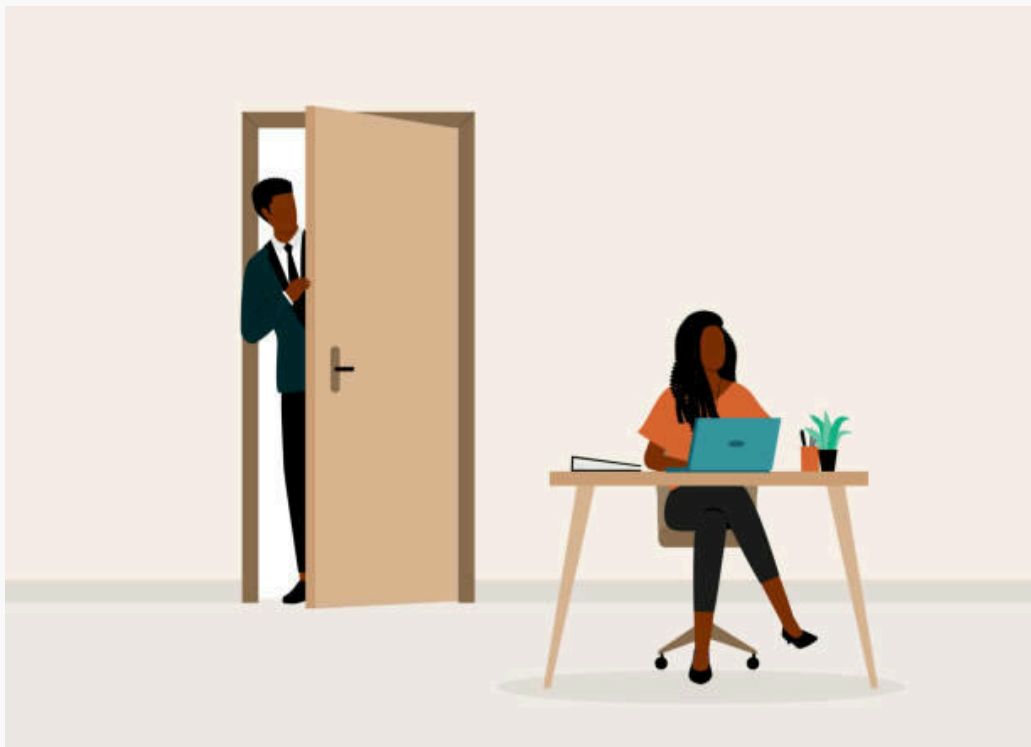
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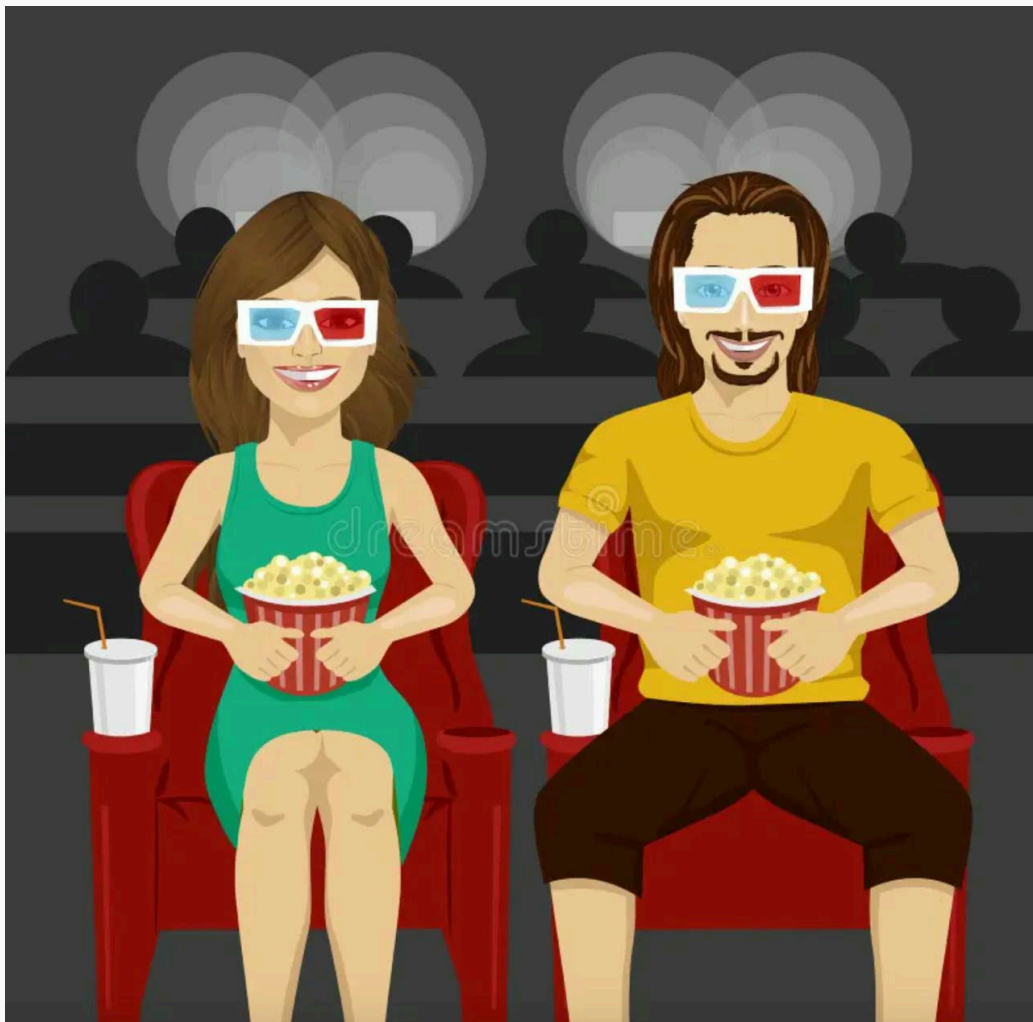
You get it done.

The Puzzle: Saturday at the Movies



You go to watch a movie.

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You go to watch a movie.

Then your boss spots you from a few rows ahead and asks you to get popcorn for them.

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Would you do this?

The Mentalistic Stance Prediction

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Boss desires: lunch, documents

Boss believes: intern will get it if asked

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But it feels WRONG. Why?

The Institutional Stance Explanation

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Boss occupies role: “CEO”

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Humans automatically track which roles are operative in each context

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The Rental Car Example

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Mentalistic stance: Transfer of Paul's beliefs/desires to Alex is strikingly odd!

Institutional stance: Unsurprising. Same role = same goals/behaviors.

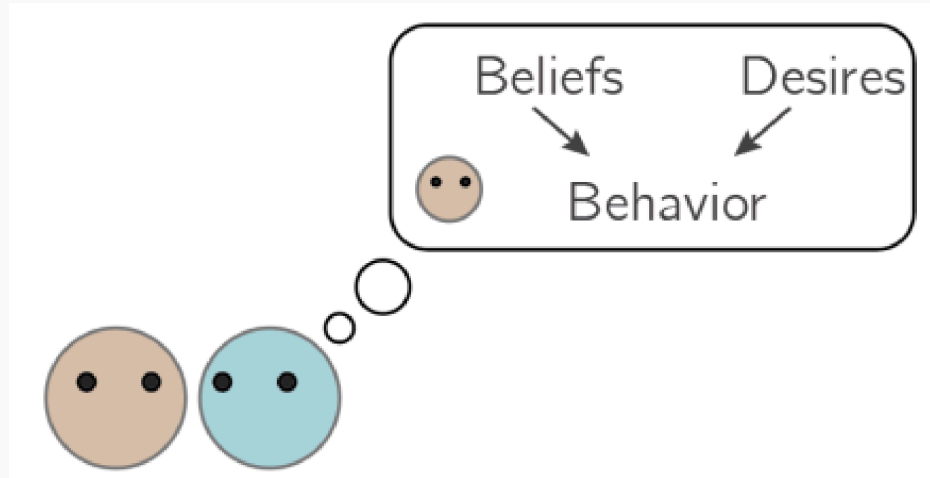
Compare to Personal Relationships

Imagine during a personal argument with a close friend, the friend excuses themselves and a casual acquaintance steps in to continue arguing...

Now it would be bizarre!

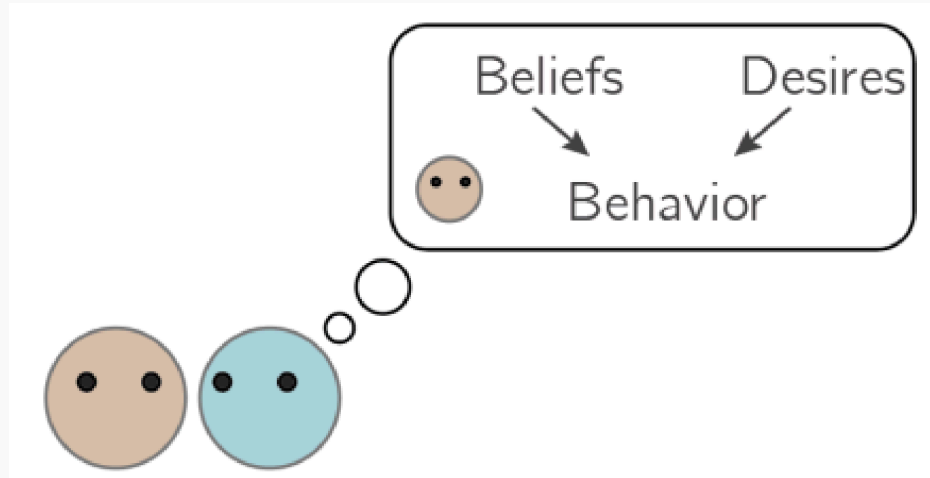
The institutional stance is **not** warranted in personal relationships—transfer of goals would be surprising, if not off-putting.

Mentalistic Stance vs Institutional Stance visualized

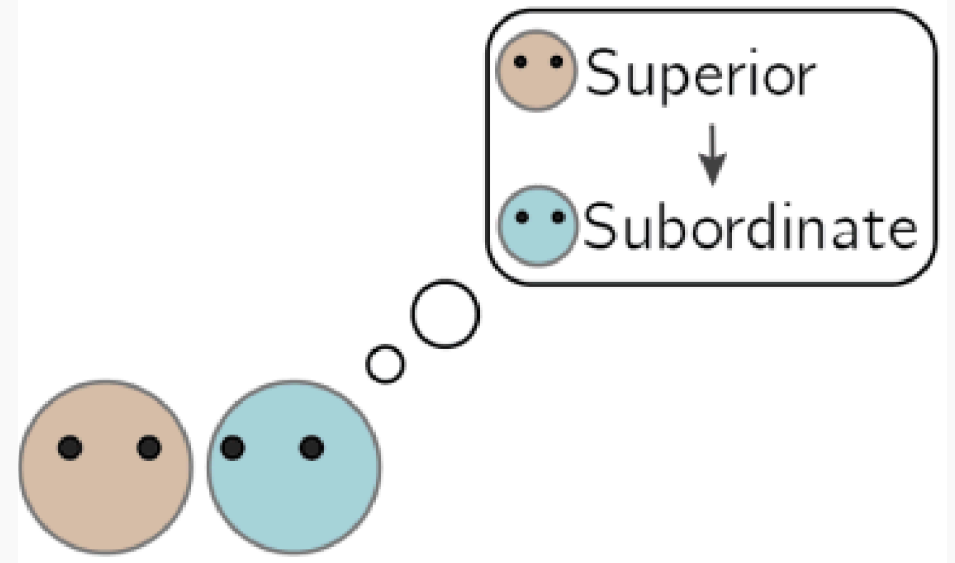


Mentalistic Stance: Individual beliefs and desires

Mentalistic Stance vs Institutional Stance visualized



Mentalistic Stance: Individual beliefs and desires



Institutional Stance: Roles and normative relations

Three Stages of the Institutional Stance

The Puzzle of Animal Social Coordination

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The Question: If animals don't have Theory of Mind, how do they coordinate and cooperate with one another?

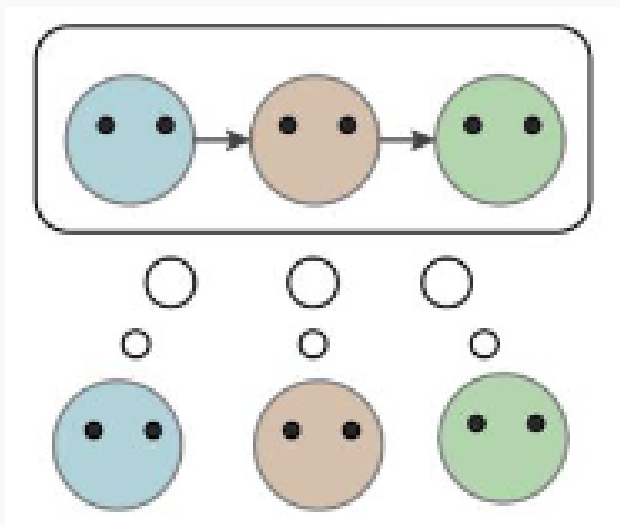
A Hypothesis: Three Critical Stages

Solutions to social coordination evolved through three critical stages:

1. **Proto-institutional:** Rigid role-based systems (biologically determined)
2. **Fixed institutional:** Role-filler independence (roles can be swapped)
3. **Generative institutional:** Grammar of institutions (uniquely human)

Each stage adds flexibility and representational power

Stage 1: Proto-Institutional Representations

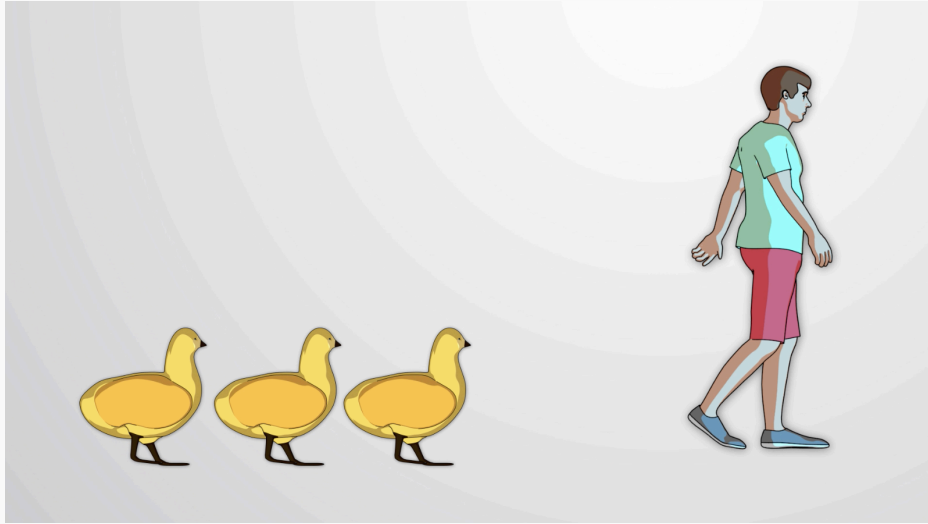


The core idea: Learn that specific individuals occupy specific roles

This allows us to:

- Predict how this individual will act
- Understand how to interact with them
- Different roles = different social affordances

Stage 1 Example: Imprinting



Shortly after hatching, ducklings identify the first moving object as “mother”

Proto-institutional representation:

- Learn to identify who occupies the “mother” role
- Associate this specific individual with caregiving behaviors
- To the duckling, mother-role and occupier of role are fused

Stage 1: Key Limitation

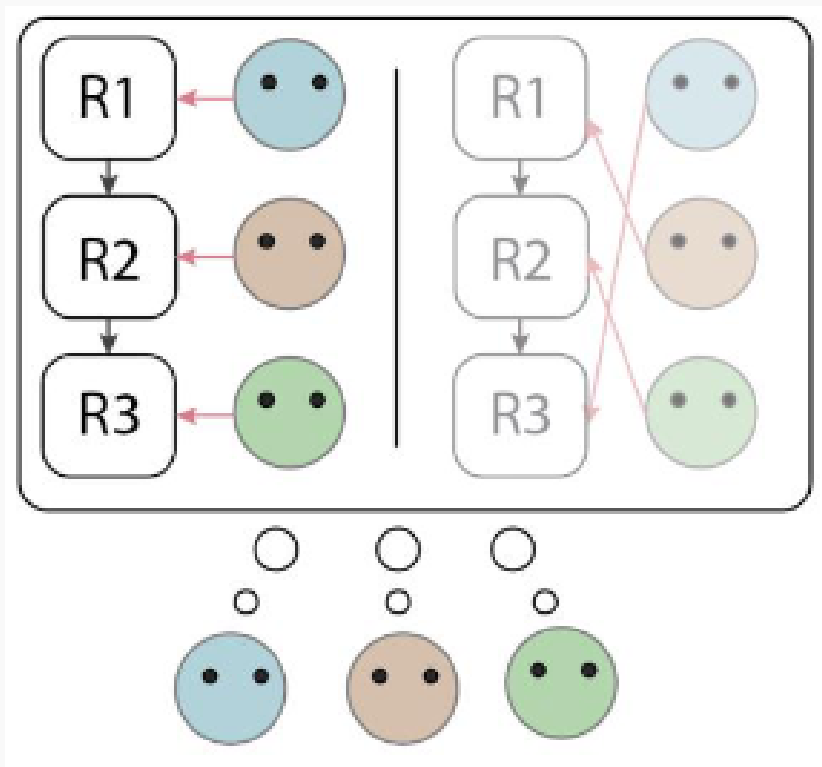
No abstract representation of role vs. occupier

The agent IS the role—just an association of specific individuals to social affordances

No role swapping possible

Still enables coordination without mentalizing

Stage 2: Fixed Institutional Representations



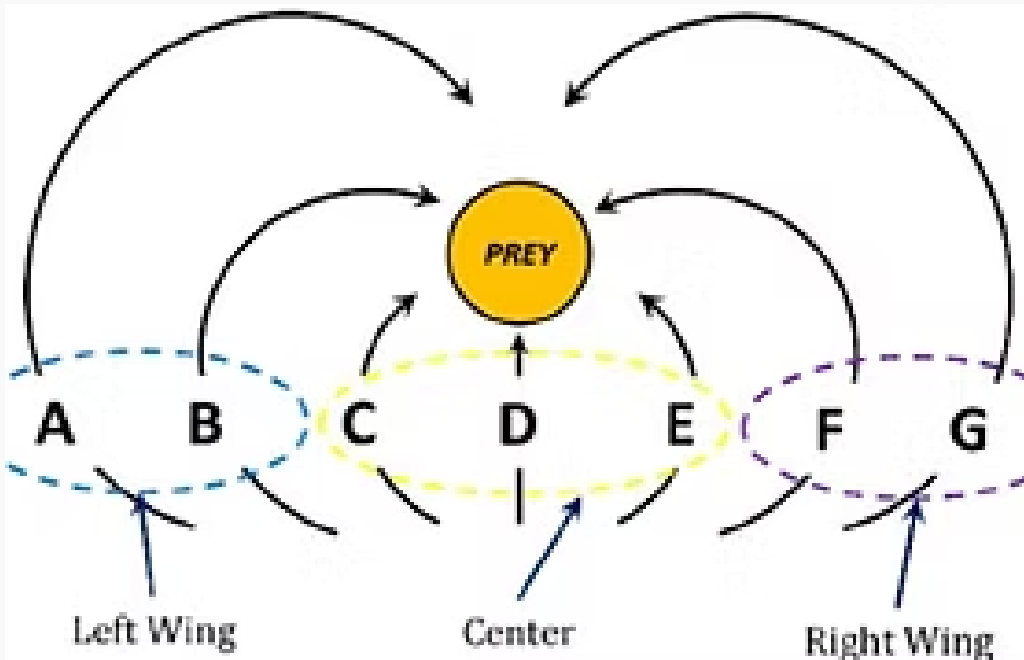
The core idea: Any individual can occupy specific roles

Abstract representation of roles independent of who occupies them

Agents can track and remember:

- Which role an individual occupies
- When roles change
- How to adjust behavior accordingly

Stage 2 Example: Lions Coordinated Hunting



Lions hunt in coordinated formations:
center hunters and wing hunters

Fixed institutional representation:

- Role specialization with ability to switch positions
- Must understand all roles need filling
- Know which role each lion currently occupies
- Can adapt when roles change

Stage 2: Key Limitation

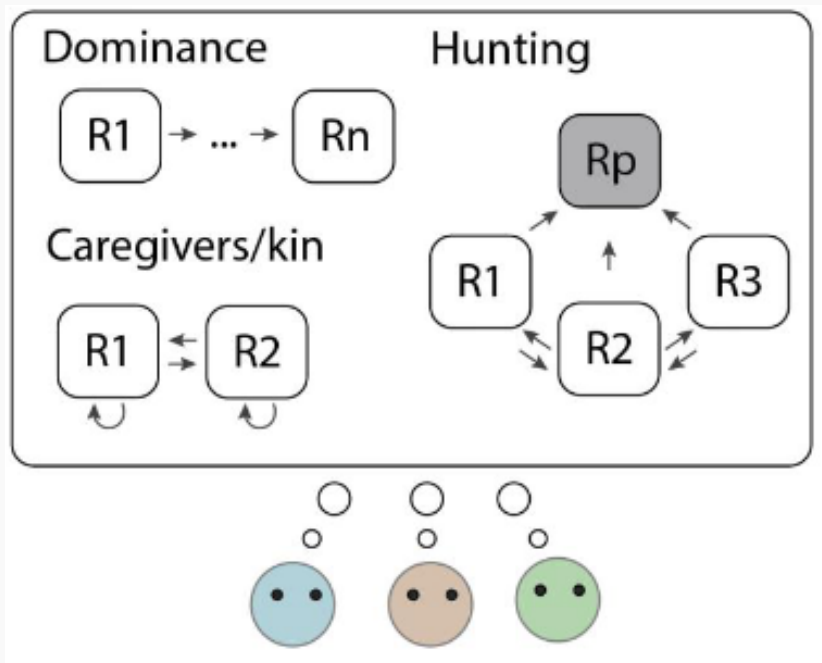
The set of roles available to interpret behavior are pre-determined

No cultural evolution or emergence of novel institutional structures

Cannot create new roles or institutional arrangements

The institutional representations are fixed—determined by biology or evolutionary history

Stage 3: Generative Institutional Representations



The core idea: Generative system to synthesize novel institutional structures

This enables us to:

1. Identify normatively structured systems of interconnected roles
2. Compositionally construct new such systems
3. Use that knowledge to interact with others

Stage 3 Example: Attending Catholic Mass as Non-Catholic



Even without prior experience, you can understand mass as an institutional structure:

- Identify roles: priest, altar servers, congregation
- Recognize hierarchical relations and ritual patterns
- Compositionally combine: religious authority + ceremony + worship
- Navigate appropriately without explicit instruction

Institutions as Graphs

What is an Institution?

An institution can be modelled as a graph of roles with normative relations

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Nodes = Roles

- Purpose: Task and Function. Who can occupy the role.
- Power: Powers granted by the role
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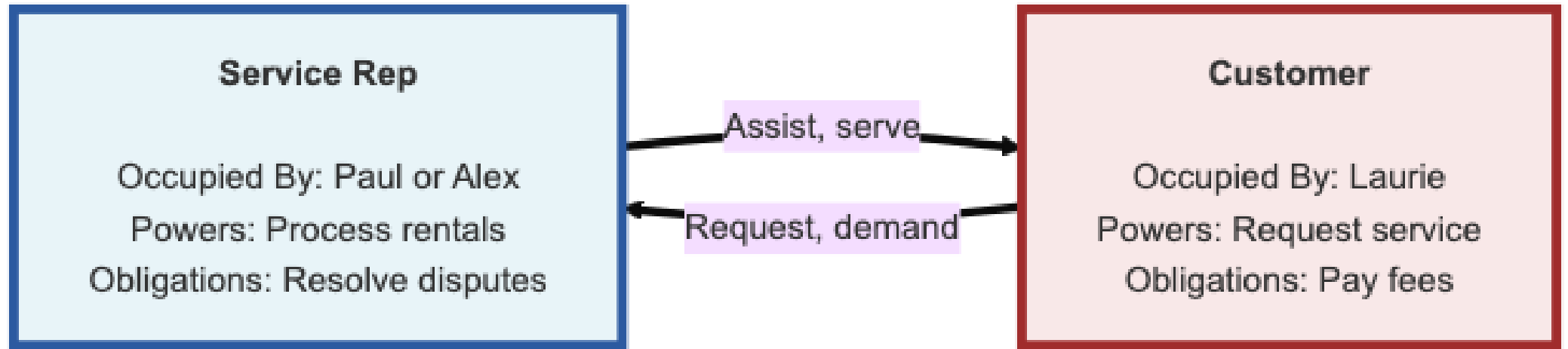
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Key insight: Roles are not isolated—they're understood as part of a broader institutional structure

Example: Rental Car Agency



Role-Filler Independence: Paul and Alex can both occupy the Service Rep role. When Alex replaces Paul, Alex inherits all norms of the role.

Discussion Question

- Do people understand each other in ways that cannot be reduced to mentalizing?
- What does it mean to reduce social reasoning to mentalizing?

Social Ontology: What is the nature of the social world?

Two philosophical stances in social ontology:

Methodological Individualism

The view that social phenomena can and should be reduced to individual agents, their beliefs, actions, and interactions.

All social facts are ultimately facts about individuals.

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Is mentalizing an individual or collective action?

The Institutional Stance as Non-Reductive Theory

Relates to work that straddles methodological individualism/collectivism

1. Representing Collectives

Categories like race and
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3. Representing Interactions and Scripts

Schemas and scripts we learn, e.g. how to order coffee in a fancy cafe

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Answer: Reasoning about when a norm becomes relevant or active in social settings requires a latent representation of the institutional structure. An account that simply enumerates injunctive and descriptive norms will be insufficient for this.

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Answer: Reasoning about when a norm becomes relevant or active in social settings requires a latent representation of the institutional structure. An account that simply enumerates injunctive and descriptive norms will be insufficient for this.

Example: When Alex replaces Paul at the rental car agency, he inherits the service rep role's norms—not because we transferred Paul's individual norms, but because both occupy the same structural position. The institutional graph activates norms based on role occupancy, not individual identity.

Creating New Institutions

The Generative Capacity of Humans

We can explicitly represent institutional structures and reason **about** them

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Reveal hidden role-based systems

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This enables two uniquely human capacities:

1. Taking an institutional stance as an analytic tool

Reveal hidden role-based systems

2. Social constitution

Create genuinely new domains of behavior and social reality

Analytic Tool: Revealing Hidden Structures

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Once revealed → we can evaluate, modify, or intentionally subvert them

Social Constitution: Creating New Realities

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Examples: Ballots, voting, citizenship

Socially Constituted vs. Socially Constructed

Socially Constructed:

Hammers, carpentry, carpenters

Social forces involved in creation, but existence doesn't require social agreement

A hammer remains a hammer even if institutions change

Socially Constituted:

Ballots, voting, citizens

Existence requires institutional structures

A ballot can cease to be a ballot through institutional change

Even without changing physical properties

Conclusion

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4. **Create new realities**

Synthesize novel institutional structures that genuinely create new social kinds The generative aspect allows us to imagine and pursue genuine institutional alternatives

Questions & Discussion